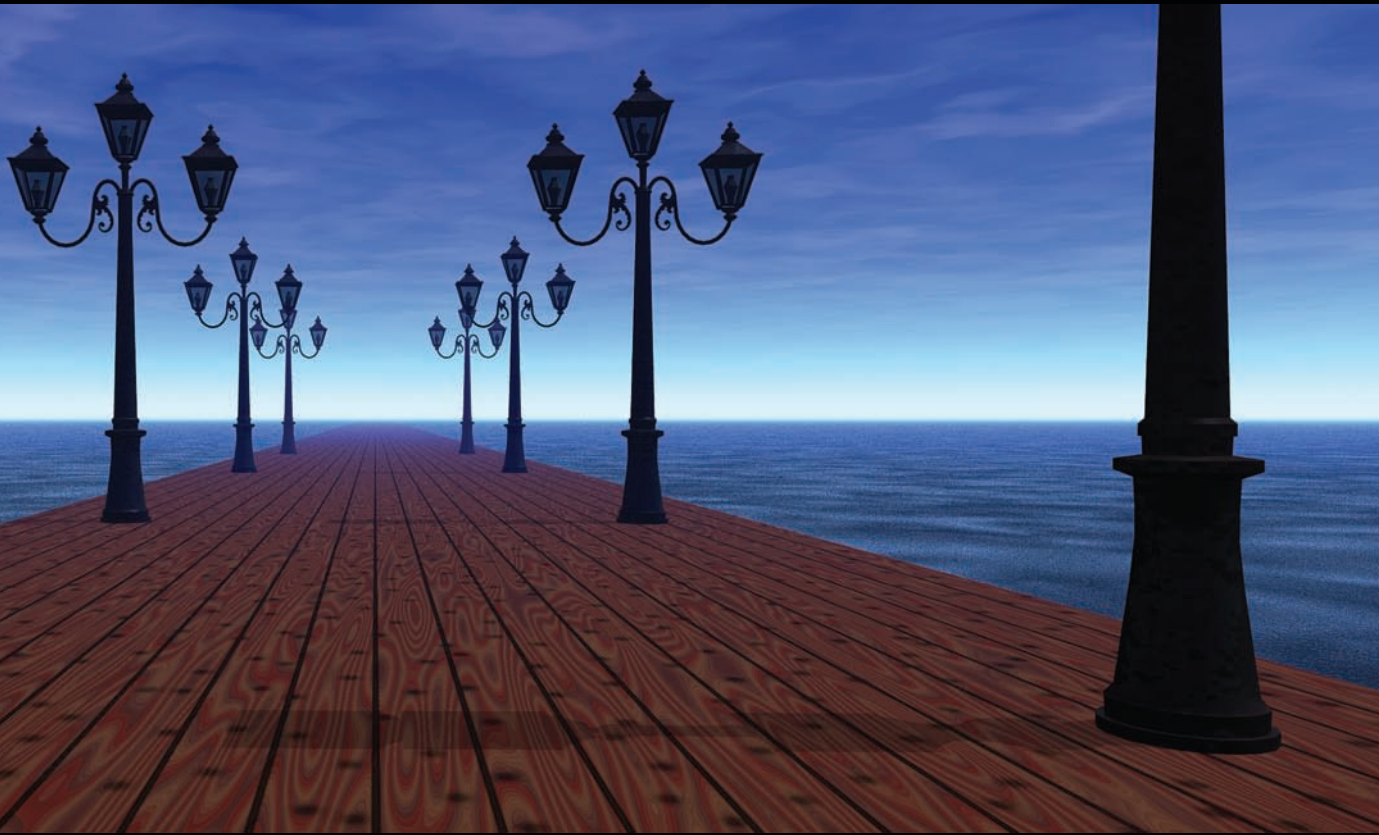


A CONCEPTUAL HISTORY OF PSYCHOLOGY



JOHN D. GREENWOOD

A Conceptual History of Psychology



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For my brother Malcolm

B R I E F C O N T E N T S



	<i>Preface</i>	xix
CHAPTER 1	<i>History, Science, and Psychology</i>	1
CHAPTER 2	<i>Ancient Greek Science and Psychology</i>	30
CHAPTER 3	<i>Rome and the Medieval Period</i>	69
CHAPTER 4	<i>The Scientific Revolution</i>	100
CHAPTER 5	<i>The Newtonian Psychologists</i>	148
CHAPTER 6	<i>Physiology and Psychology</i>	192
CHAPTER 7	<i>Theories of Evolution</i>	241
CHAPTER 8	<i>Psychology in Germany</i>	295
CHAPTER 9	<i>Psychology in America: The Early Years</i>	351
CHAPTER 10	<i>Functionalism, Behaviorism, and Mental Testing</i>	409
CHAPTER 11	<i>Neobehaviorism, Radical Behaviorism, and Problems of Behaviorism</i>	476
CHAPTER 12	<i>The Cognitive Revolution</i>	523
CHAPTER 13	<i>Abnormal and Clinical Psychology</i>	565
CHAPTER 14	<i>Social and Developmental Psychology</i>	611
EPILOGUE	<i>The Past and Future of Scientific Psychology</i>	654
	<i>Credits</i>	656
	<i>Name Index</i>	657
	<i>Subject Index</i>	668

C O N T E N T S



Preface xix

CHAPTER 1

History, Science, and Psychology 1

Why Study the History of Psychology? 2

Internal and External History 3

Zeitgeist and Great Man History 3

Presentist and Contextualist History 4

Conceptual History of Psychology 5

Science and Psychology 7

Objectivity 7

Causal Explanation 8

Empirical Evaluation 9

Atomism 12

Universality of Causal Explanation 13

Ontological Invariance 14

Explanatory Reduction 15

Determinism 16

Experimentation 17

Empiricism 19

Scientific Method 20

Philosophy and Physiology 22

Discussion Questions 24

Glossary 24

References 27

CHAPTER 2

Ancient Greek Science and Psychology 30

Greek Science 31

The Naturalists 33

<i>Thales</i>	33
<i>Anaximenes</i>	33
<i>Heraclitus</i>	34
<i>Empedocles</i>	35
<i>The Atomists: Leucippus and Democritus</i>	37
The Formalists	39
<i>Parmenides</i>	40
<i>Zeno of Elea</i>	41
<i>Pythagoras</i>	42
The Physicians	44
<i>Alcmaeon</i>	44
<i>Hippocrates</i>	44
The Philosophers	46
<i>Socrates</i>	47
<i>Plato</i>	47
Aristotle: The Science of the Psyche	49
<i>Theoretical Science</i>	50
<i>Causality and Teleology</i>	52
<i>Aristotle's Psychology</i>	54
<i>Materialism and Psychological Explanation</i>	55
<i>Sensation, Perception, and Cognition</i>	56
<i>Active and Passive Reason</i>	58
<i>Psychology and Teleology</i>	59
<i>Functionalism</i>	60
<i>Consciousness and Vitality</i>	61
The Aristotelian Legacy	62
Discussion Questions	63
Glossary	64
References	67
CHAPTER 3	
<i>Rome and the Medieval Period</i>	69
The Roman Age	70
<i>The Hellenistic Period</i>	70
<i>Alexandrian Science</i>	71

<i>Rome and Science</i>	72
<i>Neoplatonism</i>	74
<i>The Decline of the Roman Empire</i>	75
<i>The Fall of the Roman Empire</i>	78

Medieval Psychology 78

<i>Islam</i>	79
<i>European Recovery: Reason and Faith</i>	82
<i>The Christian Church and Aristotelian Philosophy</i>	84
<i>Medieval Christianity and Science</i>	87
<i>Empiriks</i>	91
<i>Anticipations</i>	92

The End of the Medieval Period 94

Discussion Questions 94

Glossary 95

References 96

CHAPTER 4

The Scientific Revolution 100

Renaissance and Reformation 101

Reformation 103

The Scientific Revolution 104

<i>The Copernican Revolution</i>	104
<i>Galileo and the New Science</i>	108
<i>Andreas Vesalius and the Scientific Revolution in Medicine</i>	111
<i>Francis Bacon and the Inductive Method</i>	112
<i>The Newtonian Synthesis</i>	117

Man the Machine 118

<i>René Descartes: Mind and Mechanism</i>	119
<i>La Mettrie: Machine Man</i>	131
<i>Thomas Hobbes: Empiricism, Materialism, and Individualism</i>	137

Mental Mechanism and Stimulus-Response Psychology 140

Discussion Questions 142

Glossary 143

References 144

CHAPTER 5	<i>The Newtonian Psychologists</i>	148
	The Newtonian Psychologists	149
	<i>Newtonian Science</i>	149
	<i>John Locke: The Underlaborer for Newtonian Science</i>	152
	<i>George Berkeley: Idealism</i>	159
	<i>David Hume: Mental Mechanism</i>	163
	<i>David Hartley: The Neurology of Association</i>	172
	<i>Sensationalists and Ideologues in France</i>	176
	Critical Responses to Newtonian Psychology	178
	<i>Realism and Common Sense</i>	179
	<i>Rationalist Reaction</i>	181
	<i>Something Completely Different</i>	184
	<i>Romanticism</i>	185
	Toward a Science of Psychology	187
	Discussion Questions	187
	Glossary	188
	References	189
CHAPTER 6	<i>Physiology and Psychology</i>	192
	Positivism	193
	Associationist Psychology	196
	<i>James Mill: Points of Consciousness</i>	196
	<i>John Stuart Mill: Mental Chemistry and Unconscious Inference</i>	197
	<i>Alexander Bain: Psychology and Physiology</i>	201
	Cerebral Localization	203
	<i>Franz Joseph Gall: Phrenology</i>	204
	<i>Pierre Flourens: Experimental Physiology</i>	209
	<i>François Magendie: The Bell-Magendie Law</i>	211
	<i>Pierre-Paul Broca: Aphasia</i>	213
	<i>Gustav Fritsch and Eduard Hitzig: The Excitability of the Cerebral Cortex</i>	214
	<i>The Sensory-Motor Theory of the Nervous System</i>	216

Experimental Physiology in Germany	220
<i>Johannes Müller: Experimental Physiology</i>	222
<i>Emil du Bois-Reymond: Electrophysiology</i>	224
<i>Hermann von Helmholtz: Physiological Psychology</i>	226
<i>Ivan Sechenov: Inhibition</i>	227
<i>Gustav Fechner: Psychophysics</i>	230
Physiological Psychology and Objective Psychology	232
Discussion Questions	233
Glossary	233
References	236

CHAPTER 7

<i>Theories of Evolution</i>	241
Early Evolutionary Theories	242
<i>Jean-Baptiste Lamarck: The Inheritance of Acquired Characteristics</i>	242
Herbert Spencer: Evolution as a Cosmic Principle	243
<i>Spencer's Theory of Evolution</i>	244
<i>Social Darwinism</i>	246
<i>Evolutionary Psychology</i>	248
<i>Spencer's Impact</i>	250
Charles Darwin: Evolution by Natural Selection	251
<i>The Voyage of the Beagle</i>	252
<i>The Theory of Evolution by Natural Selection</i>	252
<i>Darwin's Delay</i>	255
<i>The Reception of Darwin's Theory</i>	256
<i>The Descent of Man</i>	260
<i>Darwinism, Racism, and Sexism</i>	262
<i>Neo-Darwinism</i>	264
<i>Darwin's Influence on Psychology</i>	265
Francis Galton: Individual Differences and Eugenics	266
<i>Individual Differences</i>	267
<i>Nature and Nurture</i>	269
<i>Eugenics</i>	270

Mental Evolution and Comparative Psychology	273
<i>Spalding on Instinct</i>	274
<i>George John Romanes: Animal Intelligence</i>	275
<i>Conwy Lloyd Morgan: Morgan's Canon and Emergent Evolution</i>	279
Stimulus-Response Psychology	287
Discussion Questions	288
Glossary	288
References	290

CHAPTER 8

<i>Psychology in Germany</i>	295
Psychology in Germany Before Wundt	295
<i>Johann Friedrich Herbart: Dynamic Psychology</i>	296
Wilhelm Wundt: Physiological Psychology	298
<i>The Leipzig Laboratory</i>	300
<i>Physiological Psychology</i>	302
<i>Experimental Methods</i>	302
<i>Wundt's Psychology</i>	304
<i>Völkerpsychologie</i>	308
<i>Wundt's Legacy</i>	310
<i>Wundt's American Students</i>	312
German Psychology Beyond Leipzig	313
<i>Hermann Ebbinghaus: On Memory</i>	313
<i>Georg Elias Müller: The Experimentalist</i>	315
<i>Franz Brentano: Intentionality</i>	317
<i>Carl Stumpf: The Berlin Institute of Experimental Psychology</i>	319
<i>Oswald Külpe: The Würzburg School</i>	321
<i>Gestalt Psychology</i>	326
Applied Psychology in Germany	336
Discussion Questions	340
Glossary	340
References	343

CHAPTER 9

Psychology in America: The Early Years 351

Psychology and the Development of the American University 352

The Success of Psychology 356

Philosophy and Psychology 358

Applied Psychology 359

James and Münsterberg at Harvard 360

William James 360

Hugo Münsterberg 366

Ladd and Scripture at Yale 369

Hall at Johns Hopkins and Clark 370

Johns Hopkins and the New Psychology 371

Clark and Genetic Psychology 373

The American Psychological Association 374

Adolescence and Sex 376

Old Age 378

Applying the Wundtian Skeleton: Cattell, Witmer, Scott, and Wolfe 379

James McKeen Cattell: Mental Testing 379

Lightner Witmer: Clinical Psychology 383

Walter Dill Scott: Industrial Psychology 386

Harry Kirke Wolfe: Scientific Pedagogy 388

Edward B. Titchener and Structural Psychology 388

Structural Psychology 390

Inspection and Introspection 392

Völkerpsychologie and Applied Psychology 394

The Experimentalists 396

Imageless Thought 397

The Eclipse of Structural Psychology 398

Scientific and Applied Psychology 399

Discussion Questions 400

Glossary 401

References 402

CHAPTER 10*Functionalism, Behaviorism, and Mental Testing* 409

The Turn to Applied Psychology 410

Functional Psychology 411

Baldwin and Titchener on Reaction Time 412*John Dewey: Purpose and Adaptation* 415*James Rowland Angell: The Province of Functional Psychology* 418*Social Engineering* 421

Behaviorism 422

Background to Behaviorism 422*Animal Psychology* 425*Edward L. Thorndike: The Law of Effect* 429*Ivan Pavlov: Classical Conditioning* 434*John B. Watson: Psychology as the Behaviorist Views It* 437

Mental Testing, Immigration, and Sterilization 451

The Binet-Simon Intelligence Test 452*Goddard and the Feeble-minded* 453*The First World War and the Army Testing Project* 455*Immigration and Sterilization* 459

The Status of Applied Psychology 462

Discussion Questions 464

Glossary 464

References 466

CHAPTER 11*Neobehaviorism, Radical Behaviorism, and Problems of Behaviorism* 476

Neobehaviorism 477

Logical Positivism 479*Operationism* 481*Edward C. Tolman: Purposive Behaviorism* 482*Clark L. Hull: A Newtonian Behavioral System* 486*Neobehaviorist Theory and Operational Definition* 492

Radical Behaviorism	495
<i>Operant Conditioning</i>	496
<i>Explanatory Fictions</i>	497
<i>Radical Behaviorism</i>	498
The Second World War and the Professionalization of Academic Psychology	502
<i>Psychological Contributions to the War Effort</i>	502
<i>The Reorganization of the APA</i>	503
<i>Postwar Expansion</i>	504
Problems of Behaviorism	504
<i>Chomsky's Critique of Skinner</i>	505
<i>The Misbehavior of Organisms</i>	507
<i>Contiguity and Frequency</i>	509
<i>Consciousness and Conditioning</i>	511
<i>The Neurophysiology of Learning</i>	511
The Eve of the Cognitive Revolution	513
Discussion Questions	514
Glossary	514
References	516
CHAPTER 12	<i>The Cognitive Revolution</i> 523
Information Theory	524
<i>Claude Shannon: Communication Theory</i>	524
<i>Norbert Wiener: Cybernetics</i>	525
<i>Donald Broadbent: Information Processing</i>	526
<i>Computers and Cognition</i>	529
Cognitive Psychology	536
<i>Jerome Bruner: Higher Mental Processes</i>	537
<i>George Miller: Cognitive Science</i>	538
<i>Strategies, Programs, and Plans</i>	539
<i>Ulric Neisser: Cognitive Psychology</i>	540
<i>The Cognitive Revolution</i>	541
The Cognitive Revolution	543
<i>The Cognitive Revolution as "Paradigm Shift"</i>	543

*From Intervening Variables to Cognitive Hypothetical
Constructs* 545

Cognition and Behavior 547

Structuralism and Anthropomorphism 548

The Cognitive Tradition 549

Criticism and Connectionism 550

The Second Century 554

Discussion Questions 555

Glossary 556

References 557

CHAPTER 13

Abnormal and Clinical Psychology 565

Neuroses, Alienists, and Psychiatry 567

The Reform of Asylums 568

Magnetism, Mesmerism, and Hypnosis 572

Freud and Psychoanalysis 578

Studies on Hysteria 579

Psychosexual Development 580

The Reception of Freud's Theory 582

The Scientific Status of Freud's Theory 584

Scientific Psychology and Abnormal
Psychology 587

ECT, Lobotomy, and Psychopharmacology 591

Psychoactive Drugs and Institutional Care 592

The Myth of Mental Illness 593

Postwar Clinical Psychology 594

Clinical Training 595

Humanistic Psychology 596

Into the 21st Century 598

Discussion Questions 600

Glossary 600

References 602

CHAPTER 14	<i>Social and Developmental Psychology</i>	611
	Social Psychology	612
	<i>Early German and American Social Psychology</i>	614
	<i>Individualistic Social Psychology</i>	618
	<i>Social Psychology in the Postwar Period</i>	625
	Developmental Psychology	632
	<i>Scientific Psychology and Developmental Psychology</i>	633
	<i>Cognitive Development</i>	637
	Discussion Questions	639
	Glossary	639
	References	641
EPILOGUE	<i>The Past and Future of Scientific Psychology</i>	654
	<i>Credits</i>	656
	<i>Name Index</i>	657
	<i>Subject Index</i>	668

P R E F A C E



The study of the history of psychology, like the study of psychology itself, should be an intellectual adventure. This is the course in which the serious student of psychology can engage with the basic concepts that structure the field, in all its range and variation. Whether you plan a career in clinical psychology, experimental psychology, academics, or any of the other fields for which a degree in psychology helps to prepare you, this course will provide invaluable preparation. Your engagement with the assumptions, associations, and constructions that have shaped the development of psychology will help you to look beneath the surface to see how conceptual frameworks drive theory and practice—skills that you'll find are valuable and useful throughout your life.

WHY A CONCEPTUAL HISTORY OF PSYCHOLOGY?

This textbook is a *conceptual* history of psychology; it traces the continuities and discontinuities in our theoretical conceptions of human psychology and behavior from the speculations of the ancient Greeks to the institutionalized scientific psychology of the 20th century. I highlight some of the remarkable continuities that reach across centuries and millennia, such as those between Aristotle's psychology and contemporary cognitive psychology, as well as fundamental discontinuities between superficially similar theoretical positions, such as those between supposedly "liberalized" forms of neobehaviorism and cognitive psychology. I also try to tease apart historically associated positions that have no essential connection, such as the common association between materialism and the view that human psychology is continuous with animal psychology. I have found in my own teaching experience that these conceptual continuities, discontinuities, and relationships are what engage students, and help them see the significance of the subject for their own contemporary theory and practice.

INCIDENTS AND ACCIDENTS

I have made a serious attempt to illustrate the *contingency* of many of the conceptual principles and associations that have informed the historical development of psychology and that continue today to shape our conception of the contemporary discipline. I demonstrate that the general acceptance of certain conceptions of human psychology and behavior has often been the idiosyncratic product of personal, social, cultural, economic, political, religious, and institutional factors, which made certain conceptions and associations appealing to theorists at the time, even if there were no compelling theoretical or empirical reasons for accepting them. I do not dispute that many developments in the history of psychology were the product of genuine advances in theory, methodology, or empirical evidence. However, I also demonstrate that many of the conceptions of human psychology and behavior associated with them were not mandated by these advances but were rather the product of independent factors often peculiar to that time or place, such as the late-19th-century conception of humans and animals as “conscious automata,” which was supported but not established by developments in experimental physiology. To illustrate this contingency, I have included short histories of the development of the subdisciplines of clinical, social, and developmental psychology, which did not follow the general pattern of the development of psychology in the 20th century (from structural to functional psychology, and from the various phases of behaviorism to contemporary cognitive psychology).

A CRITICAL APPROACH

I have also written a work that challenges students to think *critically* about the development of psychology over the centuries; without such a critical approach, a history of psychology is not worth its salt. I hope that students will come to recognize that contemporary conceptions of scientific psychology—including their own—are powerfully shaped by the particular and sometimes peculiar manner in which the study of psychology developed. I hope that they therefore will learn to critically examine the conceptual principles and associations informing their own future theory and practice, whether as academics, clinicians, experimentalists, or everyday students of human psychology and behavior. This is essential to their creative development and to that of their discipline.

CONCEPTS AND CATEGORIES

This history of psychology is distinctive in other ways. In organizing the material, I have avoided forcing it into distorting philosophical categories, such as rationalism versus empiricism, or making it accord with schools of psychology such

as structuralism, functionalism, and behaviorism (although some of the latter is inevitable, given that certain historical developments were partly driven by the rhetoric of competing schools, notably in the 1920s and 1930s). I have instead focused on the conceptual relations between attempts to understand human psychology and behavior at different historical periods, whatever the avowed or assigned “isms” of their advocates.

Philosophical differences over theories of knowledge obscure fundamental psychological agreement between theorists, such as the commitment by rationalists such as Descartes and empiricists such as Hume to the view that human thought is essentially imagistic and necessarily conscious. Although many histories of psychology treat the psychology of Wilhelm Wundt in Germany and Edward B. Titchener in America as forms of structural psychology, in contrast to the forms of functional psychology that developed in America shortly afterward, there are radical differences between the psychology of Wundt and Titchener and fundamental affinities between Wundt’s “voluntaristic” psychology and functional psychology. For this reason, I have not followed the convention of including separate chapters on Gestalt and Freudian psychology, although these were recognized as distinctive schools of psychology in the 1930s, along with structuralism, functionalism, behaviorism, and the like. While I recognize the significance of these forms of psychology, I have accorded them the coverage I think they deserve in their historical context, given their limited influence (for better or worse) on the development of institutional scientific psychology in the 20th century.

I have not made any special attempt to represent the history of psychology as progressive and integrated, for the simple reason that often enough it was not. I have rather tried to let the historical record reveal whatever degree of progression or integration (or lack thereof) there was during any historical period. I think that any critical and honest student of the history of psychology must recognize that it represents a complex web of conceptual relations that reaches backward and forward across the centuries, including the 20th century. Instead, I have explored these conceptual relations through critical comparisons and contrasts that highlight their continued relevance for contemporary debates about the foundational principles of the discipline.

This work is intended for students taking upper undergraduate and graduate courses in the history of psychology, who have sufficient background in theories and methods of psychology to come to grips with the conceptual contours of the history of their discipline. I have included discussion questions at the end of each chapter, conceived of as food for thought. They are designed to stimulate critical thinking about some of the concepts and principles discussed within the chapters. I find that such questions arise naturally when students engage the issues raised by a conceptual history of psychology, and most of those included have come from my own students. I have also provided sets of conventional review questions

and multiple-choice assessments on the book's Web page for those who wish to use them, as well as what I hope are creative suggestions for student essays and projects.

THE NEW HISTORY OF PSYCHOLOGY

I have done my best to take into account the excellent scholarship in the history of psychology produced in the last four decades, in professional journals such as the *Journal of the History of the Behavioral Sciences* and (more recently) *History of Psychology* and in specialist monographs such as those included in the Cambridge University Press series *Studies in the History of Psychology*. As a result, I challenge many of the myths that have established themselves through repetition in traditional histories, such as the claim that during the medieval period hundreds of thousands of neurotic and psychotic women were burned at the stake because they were misdiagnosed as witches; that Wilhelm Wundt held that experimentation was inappropriate for the study of higher cognitive and social processes; that functional and behaviorist psychologies were a natural development of Darwin's theory of evolution; that John B. Watson was fired from Johns Hopkins University because of his affair with Rosalie Rayner and consequent divorce; and that contemporary cognitive psychology marks a return to the structural or "introspective" psychology of the early 20th century. I hope that as a result students will find the accounts of individuals and movements covered in this work refreshingly thought-provoking and reflective of current scholarship. While I do not expect that everyone will agree with my characterizations, I hope they will agree that I have usually made a good case for them.

I have tried to make the work critically challenging, but have also done my best to present the material in a clear and engaging style (with great help from my editors and reviewers). While I focus on conceptual continuity and discontinuity, I have also included interesting, intriguing, and sometimes downright salacious details about the personal lives of individual psychologists—not in order to sensationalize the history of psychology, but because they are integral parts of it. Students will learn how Aristotle spent his honeymoon collecting biological specimens, about the strange fate of Descartes' skull, of Dr. "Monsterwork" and his lying machine, and of John B. Watson's measurement of the female orgasm (the real reason he was fired from Johns Hopkins University). I have also included illustrations drawn from the excellent archival material that is now available, which I hope will further enliven the text and make a welcome change from collections of dead white heads.

HISTORY OF PSYCHOLOGY AND SCIENCE

I trace the development of our conception of human psychology and behavior over the past two millennia, with particular emphasis on the period of the scientific revolution in the 16th and 17th centuries, and the development of institutional scientific psychology in the 19th and 20th centuries. I also examine the development of our conception of *science* and how this has shaped our conception of a scientific psychology. I try to show that the development of scientific psychology has been powerfully shaped by commitment to a number of principles that have been historically associated with physical science, such as the principles of atomism, invariance, and universality, but whose relevance for psychology remains an open and empirical question.

I hope that this text stimulates you to reflect upon the manner in which your discipline has been powerfully shaped by its conceptual history and challenges you to cast a critical eye upon your own assumptions and associations. This is why a course in the history of psychology is important and valuable for any student of the subject: It should expand your intellectual horizon beyond your immediate theoretical, empirical, or professional interests, to the concepts that drive psychological inquiry. I hope that this text inspires you to embark on your own personal quest.

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History, Science, and Psychology

IN 1877 JAMES WARD AND JOHN VENN PETITIONED THE UNIVERSITY OF Cambridge in England to have experimental psychology introduced as an academic discipline. The University Senate refused to do so on the grounds that it would “insult religion by putting the soul on a pair of scales” (Hearnshaw, 1989, p. 125). In a 1907 paper published in *American Medicine*, Dr. Duncan Macdougall of Haverhill, Massachusetts, described his attempt to put the soul on a scale (Macdougall, 1907). He persuaded six dying patients to spend their last hours in a special bed that rested on a platform beam scale. By comparing the weight of the individual (plus bed) before and immediately after death, Macdougall estimated the weight of the human soul to be about “three-fourths of an ounce.” He repeated this experiment with 15 dying dogs, who manifested no weight loss upon expiration, confirming the popular belief that animals have no soul (Roach, 2003).

From the dawn of recorded civilization, humans have not only speculated about the nature and causes of mind and behavior, but have also employed their ingenuity to put these speculations to empirical test. In the seventh century BCE, the Egyptian King Psamtik I supposed that children with no opportunity to learn a language from other people would spontaneously develop the natural and universal language of humankind, which he presumed to be Egyptian (Hunt, 1994). He tested this hypothesis by having one of his subjects seclude a number of infants and observe which language they first spoke; he was disappointed to learn that they did not speak Egyptian. As the centuries progressed, critical thinkers continued to speculate about the nature and causes of mind and behavior and to subject their theories to empirical test. The process was accelerated by the scientific revolution in Europe in the 16th and 17th centuries and by the development of experimental physiology and evolutionary theory in the 19th century, which promoted the growth of the institutional science of psychology in the late 19th and 20th centuries. The story of this progression, development, and growth is the history of psychology.